

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4

 Snow and rain 39/22 • Tomorrow: Sunny and cold 28/13 C8 *Democracy Dies in Darkness* SUNDAY, JANUARY 19, 2025 • \$6

U.S. played big role in securing Gaza truce

Incoming and outgoing teams formed an unlikely collaboration to seal deal

BY KAREN DEYOUNG,
SHIRA RUBIN
AND GERRY SHIH

Israeli officials were scrambling. They had just been told that Steve Witkoff, President-elect Donald Trump's Middle East envoy, was on his way to Jerusalem. It was Saturday, Jan. 11 — Shabbat — and Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's government rarely held official meetings on the Jewish day of rest.

They knew little about Witkoff. He was “just some guy sent by Trump” with little experience in diplomacy or the Middle East, a former senior Israeli official said.

But by the time the billionaire real estate developer's meeting with Netanyahu was over that day, “Bibi had no choice but to say yes very quickly” to the evolving terms of a ceasefire in the war between Israel and Hamas, the former official said, using Netanyahu's nickname.

Trump's claim of full credit for the ceasefire and hostage release agreement that — after 14 months of negotiations since the last pause in fighting — is now planned to go into effect Sunday has provoked eyerolls among officials in the Biden administration. President Joe Biden responded, “Is that a joke?” when reporters asked Wednesday whether he or Trump deserved the plaudits.

Yet Biden officials involved in

SEE CEASEFIRE ON A19



NIC ANTAYA/GETTY IMAGES

Terry McLaurin, left, Jayden Daniels and the Commanders are one game from the Super Bowl after beating the Lions on Saturday.

There is no game these Commanders can't win



Barry Svrluga

DETROIT — There is no silence quite like the silence that envelops a home stadium in the playoffs when the home team is favored

and the home team falls behind. The possibility that a season of unprecedented promise could end in devastation turns the Colosseum into a college library during finals week. It's stifling.

Welcome to Ford Field on Saturday night. There, the Washington Commanders — the cute newcomers to the serious environs of the NFL postseason — about shut the place up. They ousted the Detroit Lions — the NFC's top seeds, favorites to reach their first Super Bowl — with an emphatic 45-31 victory that advanced them to their first NFC championship game since the 1991 season and made clear that there is no team they can't beat, no game they can't win.

Blink your eyes clear,

Washington. This completely new football reality will be the talk of the league — almost regardless of what happens in the two remaining divisional-round games Sunday. Rookie quarterback Jayden Daniels was again preternaturally steady and a mesmerizing star, completing 22 of 31 passes for 299 yards and two touchdowns and running for 51 more yards.

But this victory — Washington's seventh in a row but the first in weeks that didn't come down to the final play — was built on so many of

the traits first-year coach Dan Quinn has instilled in this team, of which so little was expected. The Commanders forced five turnovers and committed none, an imbalance that slowed a Detroit offense that outscored every other team in the league. They gained 182 yards and scored three touchdowns on the ground, reviving a dormant rushing game that could have been their downfall. They flew around, fought for each of their 481 yards, and wouldn't

SEE SVRLUGA ON A14

For Trump adviser, Afghanistan looms large

BY CRAIG WHITLOCK

In February 2020, Rep. Michael Waltz, then a first-term GOP lawmaker, received a coveted invitation to fly to his home state of Florida aboard Air Force One. During the flight, he seized the opportunity to lobby President Donald Trump about an issue to which he had devoted most of his career: the war in Afghanistan.

Trump had just approved a conditional peace agreement with the Taliban that called for the full withdrawal of U.S. troops within 14 months. Waltz, a Green Beret who had served two combat tours in Afghanistan, pleaded with the president to reconsider, arguing that the Taliban couldn't be trusted and that the U.S. military needed to stay indefinitely. Yet Trump, who had campaigned on a promise to end the war, was unmoved. “We've been there so long,” he told Waltz, according to the congressman's recently published memoirs. “It's time.”

Despite their fundamental disagreement over the longest war in American history, Trump has tapped Waltz to return with him to the White House as national security adviser. The job does not require Senate confirmation but is one of the most powerful posts in Washington. In an administration that Trump is stacking with figures who share his isolationist leanings, Waltz stands out as the opposite: a post 9/11 veteran who still favors

SEE WALTZ ON A10

Abortion foes look for men to report on partners

BY CAROLINE KITCHENER

As antiabortion advocates launch legal efforts to stop abortion pills from reaching women in states with bans, they are increasingly turning to one group with uniquely intimate and specific information to help them find cases: male sex partners of women who decided to end their pregnancies.

The strategy propelled a first-of-its-kind lawsuit filed last month by Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton that cited firsthand information from an unnamed “biological father” to accuse a New York doctor of illegally providing abortion pills to a woman in the Dallas area, according to

Men take legal action against doctors helping women end pregnancies

two people familiar with the case's origins.

The case was inspired by a report Paxton's office received from the man and emerged as part of a broader abortion law enforcement operation the attorney general has quietly created that includes searching for potential plaintiffs, said the two people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe private

conversations.

This partner-focused approach will shift to a more public phase next month when Texas's largest antiabortion organization launches an advertising campaign on Facebook and X to reach the husbands, boyfriends and sex partners of women who have had abortions in the state — with the goal of recruiting them to file lawsuits against those who assisted the women in ending their pregnancies.

“The strategy right now is to tell dads that if you're the father of a child victim of an abortion, you have legal rights, there may be a way to hold these people accountable,” said John Seago,

the president of Texas Right to Life, adding that his group has already found several men who could act as plaintiffs in upcoming cases.

The effort is the latest indication that, nearly three years after the fall of *Roe v. Wade* triggered strict abortion laws across the South and Midwest, antiabortion advocates have remained largely stymied in their quest to end the practice.

Thousands of women in states with bans are receiving abortion pills through the mail every month. Many are relying on just a handful of websites that distribute the pills with the help of

SEE ABORTION ON A6



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

People's March in D.C. against Trump

Demonstrators gather Saturday at the Lincoln Memorial to protest President-elect Donald Trump and Republican Party policies that they believe will undermine the rights of women, immigrants, and social and racial minorities. Organizers hope that the march will inspire protesters to turn their passions, outrage and fears into collective opposition. **Story, C1**

METRO

A D.C. Council bill would allow bottles and cans to be recycled for cash.

OPINION

LeBron James: a sense of where he is. The first installment in a series.



ARTS & STYLE

A new Munich Olympics movie targets the ethics of journalism, not war.

BOOK WORLD

A peek inside historian Robert Caro's library, hidden shelves and all.



BUSINESS

As they grow older, more women are opening their homes to roommates.

TRAVEL

The Bunny Museum, a quirky shrine to an L.A. love story, is lost in fire.

Trump riding a wave on return

CONQUERS D.C. EVEN BEFORE JOB BEGINS

Stark contrast to divisive entry in 2017, exit in 2021

BY MARIANNE LEVINE,
CLARA ENCE MORSE
AND AARON SCHAFER

President-elect Donald Trump is returning to Washington triumphant: His legal cases are behind him, corporate executives are flocking to Mar-a-Lago to meet with him, his inaugural committee has raised record sums of money for Monday's ceremony and the Republican Party is now fully in his control.

It's a stark contrast both to his 2017 inauguration — when Trump came to Washington as a political unknown without close personal relationships to his Cabinet or congressional leaders — and to his departure from the Oval Office in January 2021, when he was widely condemned for the deadly Jan. 6 attack on the U.S. Capitol by a pro-Trump mob.

Now, many of his Cabinet picks appear poised to sail through the Republican-controlled Senate, including his controversial pick for

SEE POWER ON A43



Special section: Twelve pages of coverage on the transfer of power.

Chaotic days await as political fights batter TikTok

BY DREW HARWELL

TikTok in its early days promoted itself as the “last sunny corner of the internet,” a bubbly, irreverent video app that was wildly popular and, for a time, politics-free.

But after years of grappling with a congressional broadside and geopolitical tug-of-war, the Chinese-owned platform now finds itself staring into the abyss of a nationwide ban.

TikTok seems destined to make American history on Sunday by becoming the first online speech platform to be prohibited by U.S. law.

Late Saturday, TikTok's app and website effectively shut down in the United States just before a nationwide ban against the video-sharing platform came into force. The company showed its millions of American users a pop-up message that thanked President-elect Donald Trump for indicating he will work with the company on a solution when he takes office.

The company's challenge

SEE TIKTOK ON A9

Overseas bans: How crackdowns in India, Nepal affected TikTok. **A9**

COMICS.....INSERT
OBITUARIES.....C5
OPINION PAGES.....A21
WORLD NEWS.....A18

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54101

